

AN ICON IS BORN Then prime minister Indira Gandhi, Rajiv Gandhi (extreme left) and Suzuki chairperson O. Suzuki with the Maruti 800 in New Delhi, Dec. 1983

49th ANNIVERSARY

TURNING POINTS
BUSINESS

THE MARUTI 800, 1983

The Aam Aadmi Car

The small car that made a big difference by democratising car ownership in the country and changing the face of India's automotive industry

BY M.G. ARUN

You could have dismissed it as a pretender challenging the stately Ambassador, or its more modern-looking competitor Pad, as the Premier Padmini or the Fiat was often called. But the Maruti 800, named so after its 800cc engine, proved to be a worthy David to the Goliaths produced respectively by Hindustan Motors and Premier Automobiles, eventually wiping their cars out of existence. Maruti 800 proved that a car did not have to be an item of luxury, it was a good essential for personal mobility. Its affordability, floor-shift gears and bucket seats, and reliability, made it deserving of the moniker of a 'people's car'. A perfect fit for the aspirational nuclear family of middle-class India looking to upgrade from two-wheeler to car.

The car itself was the culmination of Sanjay Gandhi's dream, left unfulfilled due to his untimely health in a plane crash. He had hammered away at the idea, interning at Rolls Royce, setting up a factory in Gurugram, building prototypes in sundry garages. But all his effort did not add up to a car. It was left to mum Indira to pick up the pieces of her son's unfinished project. Maruti Udyog was founded in 1981 with V. Krishnamurthy as chairman and R.C. Bhargava as the sales and marketing director. Bhargava remains the chairman of what's now Maruti Suzuki. They had nearly zoomed in on Daihatsu as a partner, but